Until We Meet Again

Poetry by Shane Cole



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(Dedicated to my loving grandfather, Marvin Maurice Scarbrough)

I knew this day was coming.
We all did, but that doesn't make it any easier.
We knew you were sick.
We knew that the cancer was eating away your life,
But still, we held some glimmer of hope that this day would never come.
And yet still here we are and there you lie.

To many of us, grandparents are real treasures, teaching us, loving us, and becoming a strong thread in the story of our family legacy. Southern writer Shane Cole shares the coping process of the death of his mentor--his grandfather. He shows us that such a loss doesn't magically go away, and that there is no timeline for how to grieve. He teaches us that a loved one can live on through stories, music, and memories--resulting in a loving tribute to a beautiful soul. "Until We Meet Again" by Shane Cole.

And I want to be sad. I am sad. I am.
But you've found the land where cancer does not exist,
And I can't help but think that's why there is a smirk on your lips.

Funerals shouldn't be about sadness, but they are.
Anyone that tells you they aren't are trying to fool you or they are fooled about it themselves.
I look around at my family with tear-streaked eyes and sitting down from the exhaustion they feel.
We all need a good meal and two days worth of sleep, but that won't happen today, didn't happen yesterday, or the day before or the day before that.
We've spent days, weeks, and months trying to keep you alive, but we get just one day, one hour, one minute to prepare for your death.
Yet you continue to smirk at me like I just don't get it.
What is it that you have to say?
What is it that you wish to tell me from the grave?

Because I'm just numb now. That's all I feel.
The numbness of too many emotions trying to take over at once.
People passing me with words like *"I'm sorry", "He's in a better place",* and *"if there is anything that I can do, don't hesitate to call".*

But I hear nothing. Nothing at all.
I just sit hear staring at the box built for one,
And I have to admit it's the perfect one.
You would definitely approve. They didn't pick out a girly box,
they picked one that makes a statement.
Just like you always did.
Never afraid to tell us what you thought,
and what you thought we should think.
I guess that's how I got it honestly.

As the service ends, people gather around to say their goodbyes
I sit and nod while I look them in the eyes.
Emotion coming easily to them and hard for me.
I stare across the casket as the eyes of the grandchildren all meet with the same plan in mind.

We set our task to work…so many flowers so little time.
Begin with the red roses on top of the coffin, the ones that signify love.
Each of us pulling one for ourselves and one for each family member.
When delivery is done we venture on to the ones donated by loved ones.
Roses of all colors, pink, peach, white, and orange even.
Add to those day lilies, carnations, blue bells, sunflowers, and lilies.
Beautiful colors all rolled into one large bouquet to give to our grandmother.

The smell stays with me and in my car as we journey down the interstate.

The many miles we must go to your house and wait
On the many well wishers that have come near and far
Holiday Ramblers travel from all over, as you once traveled with them, to pay their respects to you and your kin.
The meal that is prepared could feed an army.
No one can ever say Baptists don't know how to cook or feed in a time of need.
Then, one by one they leave, and it is only your wife, your children, and grandchildren left, and still I can't get that smirk of yours out of my head.

What are you thinking? What do you wish to say? What is you wanted me to know before you got away.
The answer starts to come when grandma takes me by the hand.
She places your ring on my finger and tells me to take care
Because it signified your love for all these years, and now it is on my hand feeling my heartbeat where it once felt yours.

Is this a sign of what you wanted to say? I want to understand your plan.

As I get in my car and I turn to leave I resort back to the thing I always use to escape my minds reverie.
Some are physical, some spiritual or mental, but you know me best, you know my mind is musical.

My fingers press buttons on the IPOD shuffle wanting nothing more than to absorb my thoughts into music that will take me away…
…allow me to escape into my world of imagination.
Song One, *Home* by Chris Daughtry…

"I'm going home to the place where I belong. Where you love has always been enough for me."

I hit shuffle.
Song Two, *Bring Me To Life* by Evanesence…
"How can you see into my eyes like open doors."

I hit shuffle.
Song Three, Jack Johnson's *Supposed to Be…*
"Maybe its up with the stars, maybe its under the sea, maybe its not very far…"

I hit pause. I catch my breath. Three songs randomly. Yet they all possess the message I don't want to hear, and yet it keeps hitting me in the head.

Why can't I just fix this? Why can't I just make things like they used to be? Why can't everyone just be happy?

I hit pause again and shuffle to the next song.

What they heck?
Even *Legally Blonde: The Musica* is telling me I have a *Chip on my Shoulder.*

I turn off the music and listen to the quiet instead.
Which is quite scary if you've ever heard the voices in my head.
They're telling me in unison to just breathe, and it's the first time I've realized that I haven't been.
I've been holding back, been holding out, trying to be the strong one.
Never let them see you sweat…
…Or cry as the case may be.
I'd try to explain but it won't come across easily.

I make it to my driveway and into my house.
Passing the bills left unpaid, throwing the keys on the table, and shedding the clothes until I reach my destination.
It is not long before I fall into a deep sleep.
The trouble with sleep is you are no longer in charge.
You allow your mind to tell you all the things you wish you did not know.
You allow your mind to show you the things you wish you did not see.
The things that are usually right there in front of me.

And in my dream I see you sitting there.
In my dream I wonder how that is even possible.
And its then in my dream that I see something I could not see.
You really have found the land of cancer-free.
There are no more tubes, and no more oxygen machines.
It's just you and me and our family.

You look me in the eyes and I see that same smirk that has been bugging me all day.
I see the rest of the family already knows the trick that I've been to stubborn to see.

That you are simply waiting in the land of Cancer-free for me and all of our family.
You say "*I'm sorry*", and "*I'm in a better place",* and "*If you need anything do not hesitate to call."*

And in that moment I realize that funerals are not for the dead at all.

They're for me, my family, and anyone else that has dealt with death.

To say goodbye, or as I've realized, maybe something else.
Because my grandpa looked into my eyes and he told me that he had come home to the place where he belonged, but when he looked back to see he saw through my eyes like open doors that I could not understand that this is how its supposed to be.
"Get the Chip off Your Shoulder" he smiled and said. "It really matters not that I am dead. I just made it here first, and I'll be here waiting for you when you take your ride on what I have waiting on you."

And it was then in that moment that I understood his smirk.
I got it. I understood what that look was for.
Because my grandpa knew that we would meet again.
That in no way is this the end.
And in his own way he left that message for me because he knows my mind works musically.

He left me a song so that I would know that this dream of mine was no joke. For in this funeral for the living, not the dead, he placed a song that is now stuck in my head…

"I'm gonna take a trip on the good old gospel ship. I'm going far beyond the sky. Oh, I'm gonna shout and sing until the heavens bring, and I'm bidding this world goodbye."

Okay, Grandpa, I got the message.

Until we meet again.

Song Credits:

The Old Gospel Ship
Composer: Johnson Oatman
Public Domain

Bring Me To Life
Composers: Amy Lee, Ben Moody, and David Hodges
2003

Home
Composer: Christopher Daughtry
2007

Chip On Your Shoulder (Legally Blonde The Musical)
Composers: Music and lyrics by Laurence O'Keefe and Nell Benjamin and book by Heather Hach
2007

Supposed to Be
Composer: Jack Hody Johnson
2006